turned to Ravindran and found, to his horror, that Murugan had a gun pressed into the abdomen of the NSG captain. Ravindran tightened his chokehold on the towel and whispered into Murugan's ear, 'Killing me will not help you escape. My men will catch you and roast you, because your ticket to martyrdom—the cyanide capsule—is in my hand.'

After a tense second, Murugan let go of the gun. He was shoved into a waiting car. The vehicles disappeared within seconds even as people from the food joints and tea stalls tried to figure out what was happening.

The vehicles rushed back to Malligai. That this was a big breakthrough was clear on the faces of the members of the tracking team. The interrogation of Nalini and Murugan started in separate rooms. Raju and Kanth handled Murugan; Verma and Ragothaman spoke to Nalini.

Nalini was throwing up. The team doctor found her three months pregnant. Kaarthikeyan told the team to keep her health condition in mind but certainly not offer her any sympathy. Hours passed but Nalini and Murugan remained evasive and tight-lipped. If Murugan was quiet, Nalini was animatedly arrogant. She dismissed the SIT investigators as a 'bunch of enemies that were tutored by Rajiv Gandhi'.

After some time, the interrogators switched their subjects. Verma and Ragothaman took charge of Murugan while Kanth and Raju questioned Nalini. Female officers were brought in for Nalini. Photographic evidence, incriminating documents, intercepts of wireless communication, confessions of other accused and forensic findings were thrown at them. But neither Murugan nor Nalini opened their mouths—despite the application of all interrogation techniques the SIT officers had in their bag. When Ragothaman played 'good cop' and Verma 'bad cop', Murugan played 'good suspect' and Nalini 'bad suspect' in response. How far could the SIT go to secure a confession from them? Hardball tactics were not working on the couple that had committed one of the biggest crimes in Indian history.

They were shifted to a bare, gloomy closet with just one chair. Verma told Nalini her fingerprints had been lifted from the blast site. She briefly looked into his eyes and then turned away, choosing to remain silent. Verma